

Natchez Trace Parkway

Lower Trace Self-Guided Cycling Tour

Natchez, MS → Rocky Springs, MS

PACE	LODGING	SEASON	TRANSPORT
Relaxed (4 days)	Camping	Fall	Flying

DISTANCE	DIFFICULTY	BEST SEASONS	BIKES
~82 Miles	Beginner	Spring / Fall	ROAD, HYBRID, EBIKE

ESSENTIAL INFORMATION

START POINT	Natchez Visitor Center, Natchez, MS (Milepost 0)
END POINT	Rocky Springs Campsite, MS (Milepost 54.8)
RESUPPLY	Natchez (start), Port Gibson (MP 39.2) — stock up, limited options between
CASH	Bring cash — many small towns and local restaurants are cash only
CELL SERVICE	Spotty in many sections — download offline maps before departing
TRAFFIC	No trucks or commercial vehicles ever permitted on the Parkway
WATER	Available at NPS visitor centers and campgrounds — carry 2L minimum
EMERGENCY	NPS Ranger Station: (601) 446-6672 · Call 911 for emergencies

FALL RIDING CONDITIONS

September–November brings cooler temps and fall color. October is the sweet spot. Fewer crowds than spring. B&Bs; more available but still book ahead for weekends. Daylight shorter — plan to finish riding by 5:30pm in November.

GETTING THERE & BACK

Fly into Jackson–Evers International Airport (JAN), ~90 min from Natchez. Downtown Karla Brown offers bike-friendly shuttle service from Jackson airport to Natchez — approximately \$45/person including your bike. Book in advance: find her via NatchezTraceTravel.com

DAY 1 · 1 of 4

ARRIVAL & NATCHEZ EXPLORATION

No riding today — arrival day.

Arrive in Natchez — one of the oldest cities on the Mississippi River and the southern terminus of the Trace. Spend the afternoon exploring the historic downtown, the Mississippi bluffs, and the antebellum mansions that made this one of pre-Civil War America's wealthiest cities. Dine along the bluffs tonight — the Mississippi catfish here is exceptional.

HISTORY & CONTEXT

Natchez sits on a bluff 200 feet above the Mississippi River and has been continuously inhabited for over 10,000 years. The Natchez people, one of the most complex pre-Columbian civilizations in North America, maintained their capital here until colonial wars in the 1730s dispersed them. By the early 1800s, Natchez had become the wealthiest city per capita in the United States — built on cotton and enslaved labor. The antebellum mansions you see today are the physical legacy of that era. The city was largely spared during the Civil War, which is why so much of the 19th century architecture survived intact.

POINTS OF INTEREST

● Natchez Bluffs & Under-the-Hill

[Walk](#)

The bluffs overlook the Mississippi River — best at sunset. Under-the-Hill was once the most notorious district on the frontier: gambling halls, brothels, and flatboatmen spending their earnings before the long walk home.

● Stanton Hall

[Tour](#)

One of the grandest antebellum mansions in America. Tours run daily. Allow 60-90 minutes. Book ahead in spring.

● Longwood

[Tour](#)

An unfinished octagonal mansion — construction stopped when the Civil War began and was never resumed. The upper floors still hold the builder's tools. Deeply haunting. 4.9★

● Historic Natchez City Cemetery

[Walk](#)

Extraordinary 19th century monuments and Confederate-era grave markers. Free, open daily. Allow 30 minutes.

OVERNIGHT: NATCHEZ, MS

One of the oldest cities on the Mississippi River. Rich antebellum history, excellent dining, and the most B&B options on the route.

The Burn Luxury Inn ★	\$150–200/night
Stunning antebellum property, full breakfast included, pool and gardens. Nell is an exceptional host.	Booking.com or direct
Sunnyside B&B; ★	\$125–175/night
Intimate, owner Colleen is fascinating — expect a 3-hour breakfast conversation about the home's history.	Direct: (601) 807-1148
Riverboat B&B;	\$125–150/night
Bikes welcome, great central location, homemade breakfast with farm-fresh eggs.	Direct: (601) 445-8217
Natchez Grand Hotel	\$100–150/night
Convenient downtown location, river views from some rooms. Rooms are aging — manage expectations.	Booking.com
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DINING TONIGHT

Tonight is your best dining night — Natchez has far more options than anywhere else on the route. Magnolia Grill is the classic first-night choice.

Magnolia Grill	Seafood / Southern	\$	<i>Tue–Sun 11am–9/10pm, closed Mon</i>
Shrimp & grits, river view, right Under-the-Hill. The obvious first-night pick. 4.5★ / 1,700 reviews.			(601) 446-7670
Frankie's on Main	American / Upscale	\$	<i>Tue–Sat 11am–10pm, closed Sun–Mon</i>
Renovated bank building, excellent food, great atmosphere. Best for a celebratory first night. 4.6★			(601) 861-6713
The Camp	Casual / American	\$	<i>Daily 11am–8/9pm</i>

Also Under-the-Hill, river views, more casual. Catfish, burgers, great atmosphere. 4.5★			(601) 897-0466
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BREAKFAST TOMORROW

Natchez Coffee Co	Mon–Sat 6am–5pm, Sun 6am–2pm	\$
Opens 6am. Very popular with locals. Perfect pre-ride fuel. 4.3★ / 800+ reviews.		(601) 304-1415
The Little Easy	Daily 8am–2pm (Fri also 6–9pm)	\$\$
Chicken & waffles, mimosas, charming atmosphere. Great if you have a relaxed morning. 4.3★		(601) 653-0774

DAY 2 · 2 of 4

NATCHEZ TO EMERALD MOUND

~28 miles · Rolling hills · Smooth NPS asphalt

Your first day of riding. The Parkway wraps you in forest and calm immediately. Easy pace — stop at every historical marker. The day ends just past Mount Locust, the oldest inn on the Old Trace.

TERRAIN & SURFACE

Gentle rolling terrain through dense hardwood forest. The Parkway maintains a consistent paved shoulder 3–5 feet wide for your entire day. No significant climbs — the biggest elevation changes are gradual. Surface is smooth NPS asphalt throughout. No commercial traffic ever.

HISTORY & CONTEXT

The Natchez Trace was established as a postal road in 1801, but the trail itself is far older — used for centuries by the Natchez, Choctaw, and Chickasaw peoples. Emerald Mound, your first major stop at mile 10, was the ceremonial center of a Plaquemine culture society that flourished here between 1300 and 1600 CE. Covering eight acres at its base, it is the second largest pre-Columbian earthwork in the United States. Mount Locust, further along, was the first inn built on the Trace in 1779 — one of 50 'stands' that served travelers on the 500-mile route to Nashville.

POINTS OF INTEREST

● Emerald Mound (MP 10.3)

Must Stop — Allow 30 min

Second largest Native American earthwork in the US. Climb to the top for views through the canopy. The mound itself is the size of six football fields at its base. Free, open daily.

● Mount Locust Inn (MP 15.5)

Stop — Allow 15 min

The oldest remaining inn on the Old Natchez Trace, built 1779. NPS rangers give free interpretive talks in spring. The grave of a Kaintuck boatman is nearby.

● Loess Bluff (MP 17.5)

Quick Stop

A rare exposed loess formation — the wind-deposited silt that gives this entire region its distinctive topography. Short trail to the overlook.

● Sunken Trace (MP 25.0)

Stop — Allow 15 min

Walk down into the original trail worn six to eight feet below ground level by centuries of foot traffic. One of the most atmospheric spots on the entire Trace.

LUNCH OPTIONS

Coles Creek Picnic Area (MP ~27)	NPS Picnic Area	Free
Shaded picnic tables, restrooms, water. Ideal mid-ride lunch stop. Bring food from Natchez.		
Natchez Coffee Co (pre-ride)	Cafe	\$
Opens 6am in Natchez. Stock up on food for the day before you leave — limited options until Port Gibson.		

CUE SHEET

MILE	LANDMARK	DIRECTION	NOTES
0.0	Natchez Visitor Center — START	Head N	<i>Parking, restrooms, water. Official Parkway start.</i>
1.2	Under-the-Hill area	Continue N	<i>Optional last coffee/food stop before the Trace.</i>
10.3	Emerald Mound	Turn R	MUST STOP. 2nd largest Native American mound in US. Allow 30 min.
15.5	Mount Locust Historic Inn	Continue N	<i>Oldest remaining inn on the Old Natchez Trace. NPS interpretive site.</i>
17.5	Loess Bluff	Continue N	<i>Unique geological formation. Short walk to overlook.</i>
25.0	Sunken Trace	Continue N	<i>Walk the original sunken trail worn by centuries of foot traffic.</i>
28.0	Rocky Branch — END DAY 2	Exit	Short ride to Port Gibson area lodging. Quiet roads.

OVERNIGHT: PORT GIBSON, MS

Called "too beautiful to burn" by General Grant during the Civil War. Small historic town with excellent B&B; options. Dining is limited — plan accordingly.

Isabella Bed & Breakfast ★	\$100–150/night
Cyclist-specific reviews praise this place — locked bike storage, cold drinks waiting on arrival, expert local tips. 4.9★	Direct: (601) 437-5097
Collina House	\$100–150/night
Gorgeous 1800s plantation property, very welcoming hosts Scott and Katy, full breakfast. 5.0★	Direct: (504) 481-3166
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DINING TONIGHT

Port Gibson has limited dining — ask your B&B; host for current recommendations. The 61 Fish Market on Hwy 61 closes at 7pm and is reliably excellent.

Ask your B&B; host	Local recommendation	varies	—
Port Gibson dining options change frequently. Both Isabella and Collina hosts are excellent at current restaurant recommendations. The town is small — trust local knowledge.			—
61 Fish Market	Seafood	\$	<i>Daily 9am–7pm (Sun noon–6pm)</i>
Fresh fried catfish, open until 7pm. Good early dinner option if you arrive before 6:30pm. 4.5★			<i>(601) 437-4009</i>

BREAKFAST TOMORROW

Your B&B; hosts	By arrangement	Included
Both Isabella and Collina serve full Southern breakfasts. This is genuinely the best meal option in town — take your time and fuel up for the day.		—
Mississippi's Finest	Mon–Sat 11am–3pm, closed Sun	\$
Opens at 11am — good lunch stop rather than breakfast. Fried chicken and rice & gravy are exceptional. 4.7★		<i>(601) 448-5277</i>

★ *RELAXED PACE TIP: No need to rush past Emerald Mound. Bring a snack and sit on top — the views are extraordinary and you have time.*

DAY 3 · 3 of 4

PORT GIBSON AREA TO WINDSOR RUINS

~24 miles · Gentle rolling · Smooth NPS asphalt + Windsor detour

The most memorable day on the Lower Trace — entirely at your own pace. The Windsor Ruins detour is the highlight of the entire route. Take your time. Afternoon is free to explore Port Gibson on foot.

TERRAIN & SURFACE

Another gentle day on smooth NPS asphalt. The Windsor Ruins detour onto Rodney Road is the one exception — narrow 2-lane county road, no shoulder, occasional vehicles. Ride single file and stay right. The detour is 1.5 miles each way on paved but rougher surface. Worth every foot.

HISTORY & CONTEXT

Windsor was the grandest mansion in Mississippi — 29 rooms, 45-foot columns, built in 1861 just as the Civil War began. Confederate troops used the roof as an observation post. Mark Twain used the columns as a navigation landmark on the river. The mansion survived the war but burned to the ground in 1890 at a house party when a guest dropped a cigarette. The 23 cast-iron Corinthian columns that remain are among the most haunting ruins in the American South. Port Gibson itself was famously called 'too beautiful to burn' by General Grant in 1863 — the antebellum architecture on Church Street is among the finest surviving in the region.

POINTS OF INTEREST

● Windsor Ruins (MP 30 detour) Turn onto Rodney Road at MP 30. 1.5 miles to the ruins. 23 cast-iron Corinthian columns standing in a forest clearing, wrapped in vines, open to the sky. Photographs don't prepare you for it.	Must Stop — Allow 45 min
● Port Gibson Church Street Walk Church Street for the best collection of intact antebellum architecture on the route. The Golden Hand steeple of First Presbyterian Church points skyward from every angle — no one fully agrees why.	Evening Walk
● Grindstone Ford / Mangum Mound (MP 45.7) An ancient mound at a creek crossing that was a critical waypoint on the original Trace. Creek still runs cold and clear.	Quick Stop

LUNCH OPTIONS

Coles Creek Picnic Area (MP ~35) Last reliable water and restroom stop before Port Gibson. Fill bottles here.	NPS Picnic Area	Free
Pack your own This day has no reliable restaurants until Port Gibson. Pack lunch from your B&B; breakfast or Natchez the night before.	Recommended	\$

CUE SHEET

MILE	LANDMARK	DIRECTION	NOTES
0.0	Re-enter Natchez Trace Pkwy	Head N	Resume from MP 30. Continue northbound.
11.0	Grindstone Ford / Mangum Mound	Continue N	Ancient mound and creek crossing. Good shaded rest stop.
12.0	Coles Creek Picnic Area	Continue N	Good lunch stop. Restrooms and water available.
13.2	PORT GIBSON — END DAY 3	Exit L	Turn left toward town. RESUPPLY HERE.

OVERNIGHT: PORT GIBSON, MS

Called "too beautiful to burn" by General Grant during the Civil War. Small historic town with excellent B&B; options. Dining is limited — plan accordingly.

Isabella Bed & Breakfast ★	\$100–150/night
Cyclist-specific reviews praise this place — locked bike storage, cold drinks waiting on arrival, expert local tips. 4.9★	Direct: (601) 437-5097
Collina House	\$100–150/night
Gorgeous 1800s plantation property, very welcoming hosts Scott and Katy, full breakfast. 5.0★	Direct: (504) 481-3166
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Collina House	\$100–150/night
Gorgeous 1800s plantation property, very welcoming hosts Scott and Katy, full breakfast. 5.0★	Direct: (504) 481-3166

DINING TONIGHT

Second night in Port Gibson — ask your host for tonight's recommendation. Options change frequently in small towns. The Isabella House and Collina House hosts both know exactly what's open.

Ask your B&B; host	Local recommendation	varies	—
Port Gibson dining options change frequently. Both Isabella and Collina hosts are excellent at current restaurant recommendations. The town is small — trust local knowledge.			—
61 Fish Market	Seafood	\$	Daily 9am–7pm (Sun noon–6pm)
Fresh fried catfish, open until 7pm. Good early dinner option if you arrive before 6:30pm. 4.5★			(601) 437-4009

BREAKFAST TOMORROW

Your B&B; hosts	By arrangement	Included
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Both Isabella and Collina serve full Southern breakfasts. This is genuinely the best meal option in town — take your time and fuel up for the day.		—
Mississippi's Finest	Mon–Sat 11am–3pm, closed Sun	\$
Opens at 11am — good lunch stop rather than breakfast. Fried chicken and rice & gravy are exceptional. 4.7★		(601) 448-5277

★ *Afternoon in Port Gibson: Walk Church Street and look up — the Golden Hand steeple of First Presbyterian Church points at you from every angle. Windsor Ruins is a 4-mile round trip detour — do it tomorrow morning fresh.*

DAY 4 · 4 of 4

PORT GIBSON TO ROCKY SPRINGS

~26 miles · Rolling hills · Smooth NPS asphalt to Rocky Springs

A leisurely final riding day with the best detour on the route — Windsor Ruins. The day ends at Rocky Springs, a ghost town slowly reclaimed by forest.

TERRAIN & SURFACE

A leisurely final day on the same smooth NPS surface. The only surface change is the Rocky Springs campground access road — 0.3 miles of unpaved gravel and hardpack. Road bikes with 25mm tires may want to walk this short section. All other terrain is identical to previous days: smooth asphalt, wide paved shoulder, no trucks.

HISTORY & CONTEXT

Rocky Springs was once a prosperous community of nearly 5,000 people, its wealth built on cotton in the fertile loess soil. The town had churches, stores, a post office, and homes. Then everything went wrong at once: yellow fever epidemics, the Civil War, soil exhaustion from decades of cotton monoculture, and finally the boll weevil infestation of the early 1900s. By 1930, the town was essentially abandoned. The Methodist Church, built in 1837, still stands. The spring still flows. The NPS has preserved the ruins and interprets what was lost here — a story repeated across the Deep South in the post-Civil War decades.

POINTS OF INTEREST

● Sunken Trace, Section 2 (MP 45.7)

Stop — Allow 15 min

A second, deeper section of the original worn trail. If you only walk one Sunken Trace section on your trip, make it this one.

● Owens Creek Waterfall (MP 50.0)

Quick Stop

Small waterfall off a 2-minute trail from the road. A cool, shaded rest spot on a warm day.

● Rocky Springs Ghost Town (MP 54.8)

Explore at camp

The 1837 Methodist Church and ghost town ruins are a short walk from the campsite. Walk the ruins trail at dusk — it's extraordinary at low light.

● Rocky Springs NPS Campground

Tonight's Stay

Free NPS camping, water spigot on site, bear boxes provided. No cell service. Stargazing here is exceptional on clear nights — bring a headlamp.

LUNCH OPTIONS

Pack from Port Gibson	Essential	\$
There is absolutely nothing between Port Gibson and Rocky Springs. Pack dinner and tomorrow's breakfast from Port Gibson before you leave. The 61 Fish Market closes at 7pm — arrive in Port Gibson the night before with enough time to stock up.		

CUE SHEET

MILE	LANDMARK	DIRECTION	NOTES
39.2	Port Gibson — START DAY 4	To Pkwy	Stock up food and water. Limited resupply ahead.
41.0	Windsor Ruins Turnoff	Turn LEFT	MUST STOP. 23 haunting columns in the forest. Allow 45-60 min.
41.5	Return to Parkway	Turn RIGHT	Rejoin Parkway heading north.
45.7	Sunken Trace (2nd section)	Continue N	Short walk, very worth it.
47.5	Coles Creek Picnic Area	Continue N	LAST WATER before Rocky Springs. Fill all bottles.
50.0	Owens Creek Waterfall	Continue N	Small but lovely waterfall. Easy 2-min walk off road.
54.8	Rocky Springs — END	Turn R	Free NPS camping. Water on site. Ghost town ruins and 1837 church.

■ IMPORTANT WARNINGS

- No food or dining options at Rocky Springs — carry dinner and breakfast from Port Gibson.
- No cell service — download offline maps and tell someone your plan before leaving Port Gibson.
- No power available — e-bike riders should charge fully in Port Gibson.

OVERNIGHT: ROCKY SPRINGS, MS

A ghost town at the end of the line. No services, no cell service, no restaurants — just the NPS campsite, ruins, and extraordinary stargazing.

Rocky Springs NPS Campground ★	Free
First come, first served. Water spigot on site. Bear boxes provided. The 1837 Methodist Church and ghost town ruins are a short walk away.	No reservation needed

DINING TONIGHT

- No food at Rocky Springs. You must carry dinner and breakfast from Port Gibson. There are no exceptions — the nearest restaurant is 14 miles away.

★ **ROCKY SPRINGS CAMP:** Walk the ghost town trail at dusk — ruins of stores, homes and the standing church are extraordinary. No cell service. Stargazing here is exceptional on clear nights.

GEAR LIST · NAVIGATION · SHUTTLE

WHAT TO PACK

ALL RIDERS

Navigation	Offline maps downloaded (Google Maps or Gaia GPS), this cue sheet	<i>Garmin or Wahoo GPS with GPX loaded</i>
Clothing	Padded shorts, jersey x2, lightweight rain jacket, arm warmers	<i>Chamois cream, sun sleeves for hot days</i>
Safety	Front and rear lights, helmet, ID, emergency contacts, basic first aid	<i>Personal locator beacon for remote sections</i>
Other	Cash \$50+ minimum, sunscreen, insect repellent (essential spring)	<i>Small padlock for bike at overnight stops</i>

CAMPING GEAR

Bike	Any geared bike, spare tubes x2, pump, multi-tool, chain lube	<i>Handlebar bag, frame bag, panniers for gear</i>
Camp / Sleep	Lightweight tent, sleeping bag (40°F rated), sleeping pad	<i>Camp pillow, ear plugs for wildlife nights</i>
Food & Water	2x bottles minimum, water filter (Sawyer Squeeze), 2 days emergency food	<i>Electrolyte tabs, energy gels for climbs</i>

NAVIGATION & MAPS

GPX File	Import to Garmin, Wahoo, Komoot, Ride with GPS, or Apple Maps	<i>Included in your download from openride.bike</i>
Ride with GPS	View interactive map, turn cues on your phone, export GPX	<i>ridewithgps.com — search OpenRide Natchez Trace</i>
Google Maps Offline	Download the region over WiFi before your trip	<i>Open Google Maps → find area → tap Download</i>
NPS Parkway Map	Official map with all mileposts, facilities, campgrounds marked	<i>nps.gov/natr — free PDF download</i>
Komoot	Excellent cycling-specific routing and navigation app	<i>komoot.com — search Natchez Trace</i>

SHUTTLE & LOGISTICS

Fly into Jackson–Evers International Airport (JAN), ~90 min from Natchez. Downtown Karla Brown offers bike-friendly shuttle service from Jackson airport to Natchez — approximately \$45/person including your bike. Book in advance: find her via NatchezTraceTravel.com

BikeFlights.com ships your bike to your hotel and back home. Starts around \$60 each way. Book 1–2 weeks ahead.

This route guide was curated by a professional bicycle tour guide with over 10 years of experience leading tours on the Natchez Trace Parkway. Every stop, every note, and every recommendation comes from real miles ridden on this road.

openride.bike